



Parents and Carers · Secondary · Session 2

Understanding Autistic Experience:

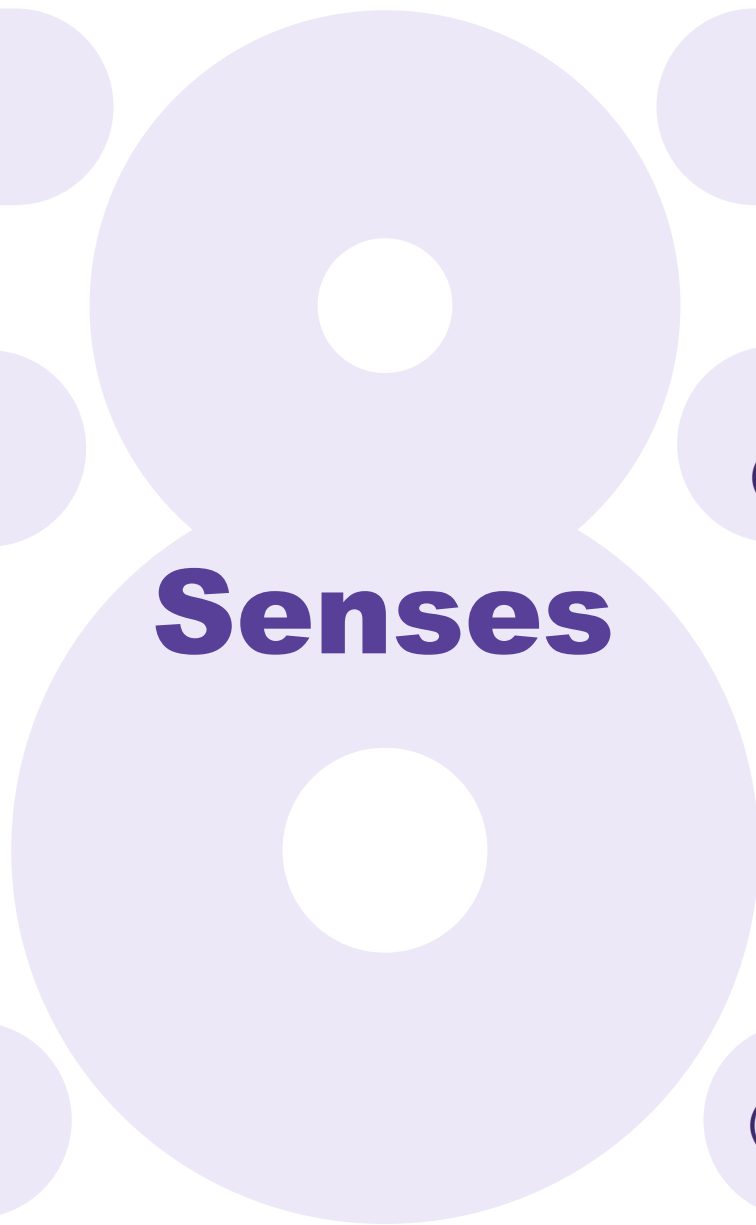
Sensory and Thinking

Sensory





What is sensory processing?



Senses



Touch



Smell



Vision

Proprioception
(Sense of body in space)



Gustatory
(Oral sensations)

Vestibular (Balance)



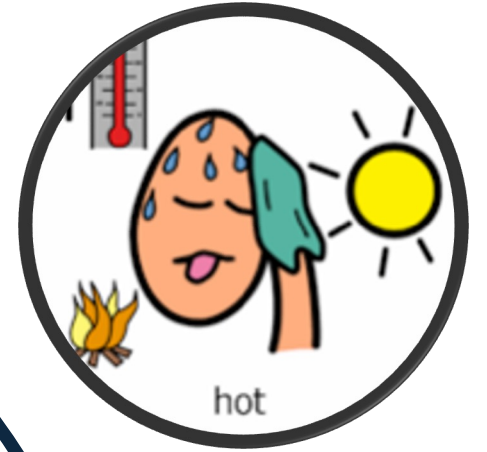
Hearing

Interoception
(Sense of internal
body signals)





**Sensory
Information**



Sensory processing

**Reaction or
Response**

Processing





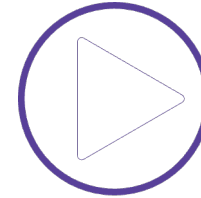
What can sensory processing
differences feel like?

Overwhelm.





Well, I can see that interaction



What can sensory processing differences feel like?

Joy.



Registration

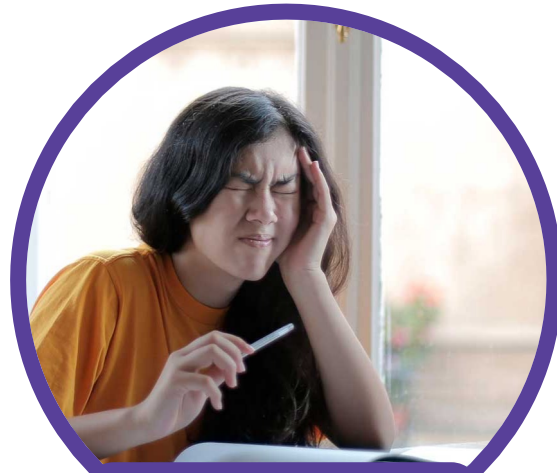


Under responsive



**Sensory
Seeking**

The 4 sensory profiles



**Sensory
Sensitive**



Over responsive



**Sensory
Avoiding**

Stimming and authentic expression

What stimming is

Repetitive movements or sounds, like pacing, tapping, fidgeting or humming.

Stimming can help your young person regulate, express joy, focus or cope. It is authentic expression and often a sign of regulation, not something to stop by default.

What you can do

- Notice what it does for your young person.
- Make space for it. Fidget tools and music can help.
- Many teens mask stims at school. Home can be a break from that.
- Respect their privacy, and only redirect if it causes harm.
- Help others understand.

Sensory Activity

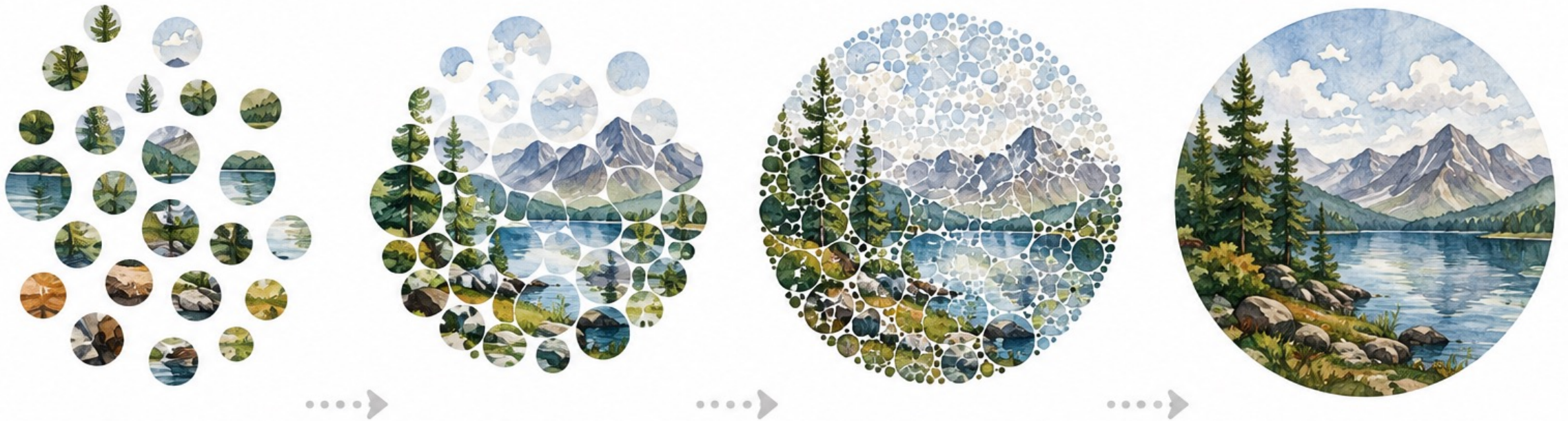
Choose one familiar routine at home, like getting ready in the morning, dinner or winding down at night.

- ① What sensory demands does it create?
- ② What could make it easier, or give more choice?
- ③ What would you like to find out from your young person?

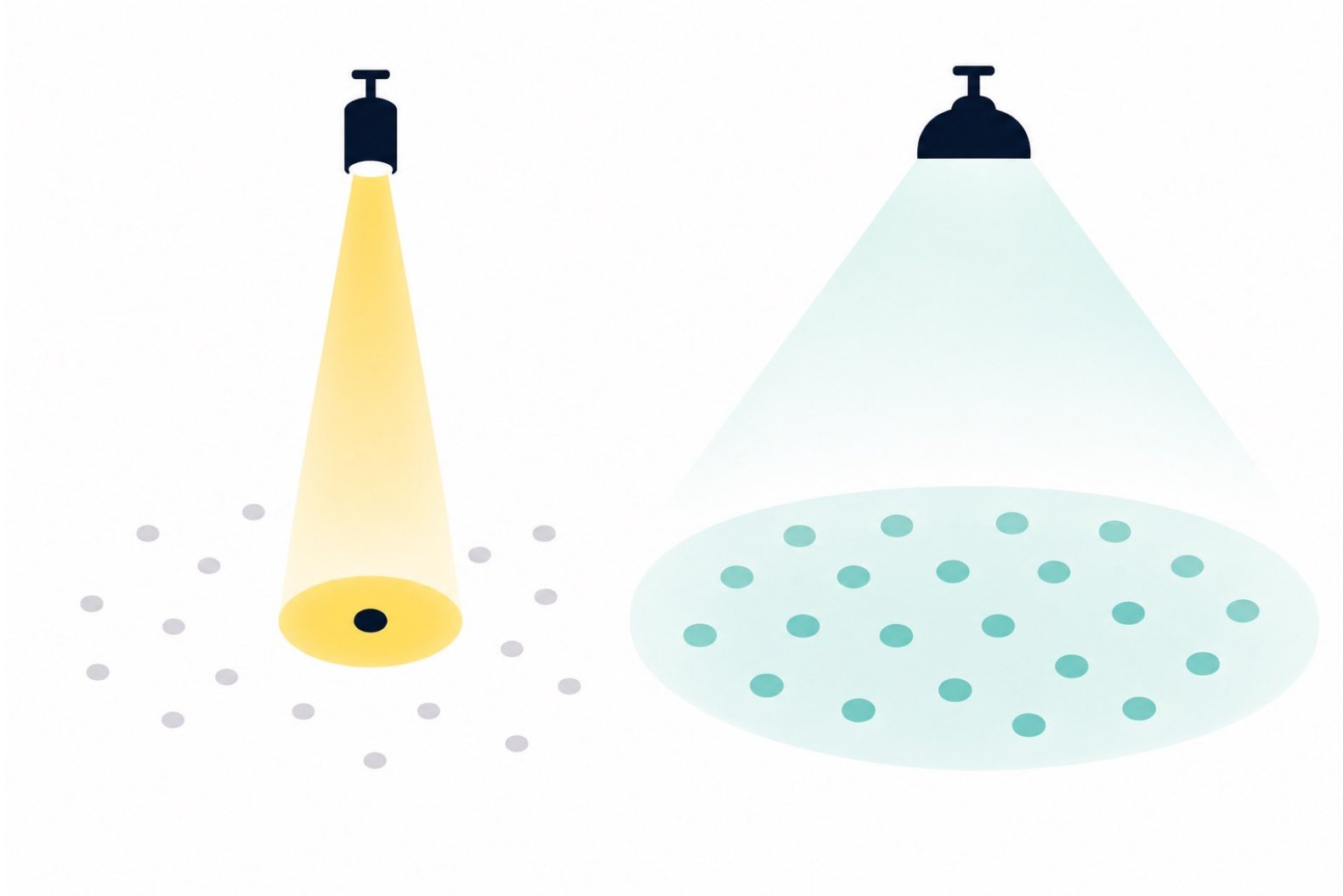


Thinking

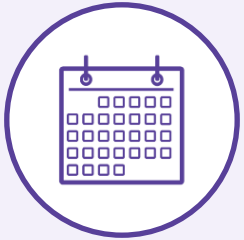
The Detail-First Brain



The Deep Focus Brain



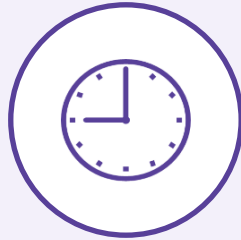
Executive Functioning



Planning



Organisation



**Time
management**



Working memory



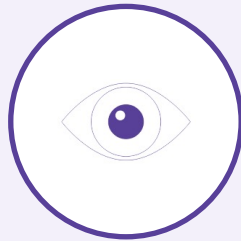
Meta-cognition
(thinking about our own
thinking)



**Emotional
regulation**



Flexibility



Attention



Task initiation



Persistence

Executive functioning example

Getting started on a task

Detail-First Brain

Starting can be hard when the whole task is not clear yet.

Your young person may not be able to identify the first step they need to take to get started.



Executive functioning example

Switching focus



Deep Focus Brain

It can be difficult for your young person to stop what they are doing and switch focus.

Transitions and unexpected interruptions can feel big because the mind is deeply focused on a task - it can feel like 'tunnel vision' for the mind.



How can Autistic thinking feel?

Video placeholder:
young person talking about what it
feels like to focus on something /
hard to transition / tendril-theory



Discussion activity



- What are your young person's deep interests?
- What do you notice about when they are fully engaged with these interests?
- When does your young person have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?
- Have you seen your young person fully absorbed in something at home? What were they doing?

Internal signals



Making sense of what's happening inside

Interoception

Understanding our body's internal signals

Temperature

Hunger

Thirst

Do I need the bathroom?



Alexithymia

Difficulty identifying and describing emotions and feelings

Am I excited or am I anxious?

Is crying always sadness?

What is my friend feeling?

Reading the signs:

Building understanding together

Sometimes young people experience a build-up inside of them, but the surface does not show it.

The more we understand a young person's early signs, the less we wait for distress to become obvious.

Building a 'map' (a shared understanding) of these signs together with others can help everyone respond in a more consistent way.



Discussion activity



- What signs and changes do you notice before your young person becomes overwhelmed?
- What would be useful for others to know about these signs?



After Morning Tea

Communication, connection and managing daily capacity

